On May 16, 1933, Max Planck, the physicist whose black-body radiation law had set off the quantum revolution, met with Adolf Hitler. As the head of the Kaiser-Wilhelm-Gesellschaft, the foremost scientific institute in Germany, it was customary for Planck to meet with new heads of state. Hitler had been chancellor for less than four months, and he had already seized dictatorial power over the young Weimar Republic, using the threat of domestic terrorism in the aftermath of the Reichstag fire as an excuse. Now, Hitler had passed a law decreeing that anyone not of "pure Aryan" descent was barred from holding any civil service jobs, including public university professorships. For Planck, this was simply a step too far. Surely "there are different kinds of Jews, some valuable for mankind and others worthless," Planck told Hitler, "and that distinction must be made."

"That is not right," replied Hitler. "A Jew is a Jew. All Jews stick together, like leeches."

Planck tried a different tack. "It would be self-mutilation to make valuable Jews emigrate, since we need their scientific work."

At the suggestion that he could ever need the help of a Jew, Hitler snapped. "If the dismissal of Jewish scientists means the annihilation of contemporary German science, then we shall do without science for a few years!" Speaking faster and faster, Planck recalled later, the Führer "whipped himself into such a frenzy that I had no choice except to fall silent and leave." Jews no longer had a place in German science, and there was nothing Planck could do about it.

Germany's universities, all of which were public, had been at the heart of European intellectual life for over a century. Now, 1,600 scholars were out of a job. The burden fell disproportionately on the sciences: since nineteenth-century German idealist philosophy had sneered at the sciences as "materialistic" and therefore inferior, there had been fewer impediments to Jews advancing in the sciences. Now, over a hundred German physicists were unemployed—a full quarter of all physicists in what had been the unrivaled center of the physics world. With a single act, physics in Germany had been destroyed.

Einstein would have been first among the newly unemployed—but he had seen Germany's fate coming. He and his wife Elsa had left their home in Berlin to tour the United States months before Hitler came to power.